

PR Measurement Masterclass

From Reporting to Insight:
How PR Measurement Becomes Strategic



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Featuring expert insights from leading independent measurement consultants
and AMEC Board Members:



Paul Hender



Steph Bridgman

Both are impartial on platforms and data points and serve as board members of the
Association for Measurement and Evaluation of Communication (AMEC).
Paul also leads the AMEC Measurement Diploma course.

Contents

Introduction

The Reality of PR Reporting Today

Chapter 1: Start With Objectives, Not Outputs

Why measurement begins before the campaign launches

Chapter 2: The Reach Metrics Minefield

Navigating impressions, unique visitors, and the case for smaller numbers

Chapter 3: The Evolution From Visibility to Insight

Three stages every PR team must progress through

Chapter 4: Five Classification Hacks

Practical techniques to save time and drive strategy

Chapter 5: Telling the Data Story

From spaghetti dashboards to killer one-pagers

Chapter 6: Who Should Own Measurement?

Building measurement capability in agencies and in-house teams

Chapter 7: The Future of PR Measurement

AI, attribution, and the case for structured data

Conclusion & Resources

Introduction: The Reality of PR Reporting

In the fast-paced world of public relations, we often find ourselves trapped in a cycle of retrospective reporting. Ask yourself honestly: How many of us report monthly? How many report at the end of a campaign? And crucially, **how many of us use that report to actively change what we are doing next week?**

The uncomfortable truth is that most PR reporting is descriptive. It closes the loop after the moment has passed. Campaign wrap-ups, monthly summaries, and volume-and-reach metrics dominate our outputs. But this approach leaves us perpetually looking in the rear-view mirror while other marketing disciplines are navigating by GPS.

Paid media teams optimise weekly. Sales teams track their pipeline daily. PR is often the only function that says, “*Here’s what we did,*” instead of, “*Here’s what we’re learning — and here’s what we’re changing.*”

When data-led insight is not frequently shared, confidence drops. Stakeholders do not feel involved. Other marketing disciplines claim impact. And senior leaders are left without the evidence they need to justify continued investment in PR.

Retrospective Reporting	Strategic Measurement
What happened?	What’s happening?
How much coverage?	Which narratives are winning?
Where did we land?	Where should we focus next?
Output-focused	Decision-focused

This masterclass draws on insights from two leading independent measurement consultants — **Paul Hender** and **Steph Bridgman** — who serve as AMEC board members and work with organisations of all sizes to embed strategic measurement into their communications practice. Their advice is impartial, practical, and grounded in decades of experience.

Chapter 1: Start With Objectives, Not Outputs

The single most important principle in PR measurement is deceptively simple: **start with what you are trying to achieve**. Before selecting data points, before choosing tools, before building dashboards, you must be clear on the communications objectives.

“Measurement really should be about measuring what communications is intended to achieve. So it’s really about aligning those data points with what the objectives are. My starting point would always be starting with objectives and then working back from there for the data points that would then tell the journey to those objectives.”

— Paul Hender, AMEC Board Member & Diploma Course Lead

Communications can achieve many different things and serves many different purposes. There is a significant difference between a short product launch with a very specific call to action and a longer-term brand-building programme. The tools and data points you use for each will vary considerably.

Paul recommends thinking in three layers — what he calls the **“See, Think, Do”** framework:

Layer	Objective	What to Measure
See	Raising awareness — audiences becoming aware of your brand	Media volume, reach, Google Search Trends, brand tracking
Think	Changing perceptions or repositioning the brand	Key message delivery, sentiment, messaging in target media, market research on brand positioning
Do	Driving a specific action (website visits, downloads, sign-ups)	Call-to-action presence, website traffic correlations, Google Analytics referrals, conversion data

“Comms is more than just coverage. And sometimes the data point is — if you are in crisis — you’re trying to keep an organisation out of the media. So the data point is almost zero. Or it might be a behaviour change communications campaign, so the data points might be beyond media.”

— Paul Hender

This principle traces back further than many realise. As Paul shared, the political scientist Harold Lasswell articulated in 1948 that communications is about “*who says what, in which channel, to whom, with what effect.*” Despite everything that has changed since then, that framework still broadly applies today.

Key Takeaway

The most important thing is not the single data point. It is how you bring those data points together to tell a broader narrative that maps back to your objectives.

Chapter 2: The Reach Metrics Minefield

If you spoke to ten different people measuring their media coverage, around nine out of ten would be trying to identify a reach or audience figure for that coverage. You count your clips, you count your articles, and then the next question is always: *who did this reach?* This is where many of the problems begin.

“There’s a risk around just counting up raw reach numbers or impressions and coming up with a very large number — because that can be incredible. You can come up with very large numbers that just lose credibility when you’re presenting it to a senior marketer or CEO.”

— Paul Hender

The Problem With Big Numbers

Consider a UK-based campaign that claims 200 million gross impressions. There are roughly 67 million people in the country. Immediately, the number strains credibility. And of those people, how many are actually in your target audience?

The problem compounds over time. If you claim 200 million impressions per month and multiply by twelve, the annual figures become astronomical and entirely meaningless. As Steph points out, you are often double-counting the same individuals.

“I always advocate for the smaller number because your outcome number — an outcome is actually then what people did after the comms campaign, after they saw it. The reach figure is an indication of what they saw. But then if you only sold five widgets as a result of it, the balance between how many people see it and how much product you’ve shifted is very unbalanced. You could run the risk of being criticised for wasting effort.”

— Steph Bridgman, AMEC Board Member

Understanding Your Data Sources

A common question we receive at CoverageBook is why the same data source — SimilarWeb, for example — can produce different numbers depending on how it is configured. The answer lies in the time window and methodology.

“What does unique monthly visitors mean as a metric? It means how many people will go to that website, the domain, over the course of a month. Once you understand that, then you are more likely to go, okay, I understand why you’re not adding those two articles together. But it raises a bigger question — if it’s the overall number of people seeing the domain, the number of people seeing my particular article is going to be a lot less than that. It might be 50 times less.”

— Paul Hender

“I think it’s just about having the confidence and the desire to seek out the smaller number and to realise that the smaller numbers are actually better numbers. People’s egos get in the way when they’re searching out a reach figure, and that’s where it leads them to report on these large numbers that don’t bear any resemblance to the likely outcome.”

— Steph Bridgman

From Vanity Metric to Sanity Metric

CoverageBook uses a methodology to estimate how many people would see an individual article within a domain, rather than simply reporting the total domain traffic. This moves you from a **vanity metric** to a **sanity metric**.

“I wouldn’t be over-reliant on one data point. Using reach as a comparative metric can be very useful — plotting trends over time, comparing your campaign against a competitor campaign, or seeing if you got a bigger bang for buck within one set of media versus another. That’s using it as an index, not for vanity purposes.”

— Paul Hender

Key Takeaway

Be comfortable with smaller, credible numbers. They will serve you far better in the boardroom than inflated figures that collapse under scrutiny. Use reach as a comparative tool, not a vanity badge.

Chapter 3: The Evolution From Visibility to Insight

PR measurement is not a single leap; it is an evolution through three stages. Understanding where you currently sit — and what the next step looks like — is essential for making progress without becoming overwhelmed.

Stage	What It Looks Like	Capabilities
1. Visibility	Coverage gathered in one place	Up-to-date metrics, easy querying, professional reporting
2. Structure	Consistent classification applied	Defined categories, clear message tracking, comparable datasets
3. Insight	Data drives decisions	Pattern recognition, narrative tracking, activity-to-outcome correlation, real-time strategic adjustment

Most teams are comfortable at Stage 1. The challenge is making the leap to Stage 2, where you begin classifying coverage consistently so that it can be compared and analysed over time. This is where the real strategic value begins to emerge.

At Stage 2, you should be tracking fields such as: primary topic or theme, key message presence (Y/N), spokesperson featured, narrative type (thought leadership, product launch, reactive), brand in headline (Y/N), image included, backlink included, sentiment (manual, not purely AI), and call-to-action presence.

Stage 3 is where measurement becomes truly strategic. It is where you can say things like: *“Our celebrity endorsement is getting lots of coverage, BUT it is low on engagements and the brand mentions are at the end of the article — SO we will not be continuing the partnership next month.”* That is the kind of insight that changes decisions.

What Senior Leaders Actually Want

They want **insight on audience** (who are we reaching?), **confidence in direction** (are we on the right track?), and **evidence for investment** (is this worth the spend?). They are used to real-time data from every other function. PR must meet that expectation.

Chapter 4: Five Classification Hacks to Save Time & Drive Strategy

PR analysis is no longer an afterthought. This IS part of the modern PR role. Share the tasks with the whole team. Analysts can help with deep insights, but the tracking and structuring of data must be owned by PR professionals. Here are five practical hacks to get you started.

Hack 1: Value Your Time — Tools vs. Human Input

Understanding where tools can speed things up and what requires human input is critical. CoverageBook's Coverage Vault acts as a treasure trove of all your account-wide coverage data. You can search your database, refine by client, media type, or time period, and export an automated CSV that gets you 50% of the way there.

"You've turned a bunch of URLs, which is unstructured data, into structured data. CoverageBook does a lot of the heavy lifting for you. Pull in that useful metadata, and then you can enrich that CSV file — add some columns to the right-hand side and enrich it yourself."

— Steph Bridgman

A practical tip from Steph: always save your CSV as an Excel file immediately. If you do not, the formatting can be lost and everything gets jumbled.

Hack 2: Categorise for Insight, Not Just Volume

Question every category and ask: what insight will this deliver? Start simple. What does tiered media really tell stakeholders? The prominence, sentiment, and context of the brand mention will deliver far more strategic insight.

“What does our ideal article look like? Our message in the headline. It’s positive. It’s delivered our message. It features a spokesperson. It features our research. It features a call-to-action. Brilliant. Let’s structure that. Each one is a column. Yes, no, yes, no. And then very simply on your spreadsheet, you can count how many times you’ve said yes — often divided by your number of articles. So you’re saying the percentage of coverage that featured our research was 86%, and that’s a really useful data point.”

— Paul Hender

Hack 3: Prominence — Are You Mentioned Where It Matters?

Not all mentions are created equal. According to Reuters, **8 out of 10 people only read the headline** of an article, while only 2 out of 10 read the full content. On Facebook, about 75% of links are shared without being clicked. Roughly 55% of page views on news sites last less than 15 seconds.

“There is a stat that 80% of people only read the headline and don’t read the article, so it can often be said that those who have a lot of coverage — one of the first steps they can do is to focus on analysing their headlines if they can’t afford to analyse their millions of articles, because the headline is all-important and it’s the headline that then gets shared on X or Facebook.”

— Steph Bridgman

A simple, practical step: use the headline column already in your CoverageBook CSV export, create a yes/no column beside it, and search for your brand name.

Hack 4: Visualise Insights Regularly

Connecting PR activity to real-world outcomes is the holy grail of measurement. By mapping web visits over the number of articles, you can demonstrate how traffic stagnates in periods without coverage and spikes when coverage increases.

Similarly, mapping event ticket registrations against estimated coverage reach can reveal that the largest spike in coverage corresponds with the largest event sign-ups the following month. Tools like **CoverageImpact.com** allow you to layer on data like sales, web traffic, or search trends and connect PR activity to organisational impact.

Hack 5: Budget Confidence — CPM for Coverage

Calculating the Cost Per Mille (CPM) for impressions of coverage helps build budget confidence and allows you to compare PR efficiency against other marketing channels. CoverageBook provides a free CPM calculator at coveragebook.com/calculator/cpm-calculator.

Key Takeaway

Remember the mantra: “Here’s what we’re learning — and here’s what we’re changing.” Every classification hack should serve this goal.

Chapter 5: Telling the Data Story

There is a significant difference between buying a monitoring platform and having a load of data points thrown at you like spaghetti on a wall, and actually packaging that information into something a marketing director can act upon in under five minutes.

“Data is not a scarce resource. Our attention is a scarce resource. And if we are communicating to a really senior person, you might have less than five minutes to convey that message. If you throw a dashboard with a million data points, they’re going to say, ‘What does that mean?’”

— Paul Hender

The art of measurement often lies in how you create the narrative. PR agencies are typically very good at packaging stories and doing the storytelling — they are less confident on the data side. But when you combine strong data with strong storytelling, the results are powerful.

The One-Slide Principle

You can do months and months of analysis, but often all you need to share is one slide with one killer point. Something that can be said in 30 seconds. As the saying goes, *“I would have written you a shorter letter, but I didn’t have time.”*

“The squint test — if you are looking at a page that’s supposed to convey information, squint, so make it blurry. Then what leaps out at you? Because if it just goes into a blur and there’s lots of stuff, it’s not serving its purpose. Every bit of information on that one-pager should be directing your eye.”

— Paul Hender

Recommended Reading

Book	Author	Why It Matters
<i>Data Story</i>	Brent Dykes	A brilliant holistic view of how you can tell stories with data

<i>Storytelling with Data</i>	Cole Nussbaumer Knaflitz	The best practical guide for data visualisations — strips everything back to the simplest way of conveying information
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On Coverage Scoring

A common question is whether scoring coverage is useful. The honest answer: it can be, as long as everyone understands what it means.

“Every score is made up of its constituent parts — an element of reach, target audience, quality of message delivery, sentiment. But if your car stops, it stops for a reason. You need to know which particular thing went wrong. In the same way, you always want to go back to the individual things that led to the score.”

— **Steph Bridgman**

“If it takes you too long to explain it, back to this point about attention being the limiting factor — then that’s a problem.”

— **Paul Hender**

Chapter 6: Who Should Own Measurement?

There is an important distinction between monitoring and measurement that the industry often overlooks. Monitoring platforms provide content in a timely, almost real-time way at the point of publication. But they cannot properly report on reach because reach has not yet happened at the point of publication — it takes 24 hours, 48 hours, a week, or even a month to materialise.

“Reach takes time to occur. I think it is incumbent on a measurement specialist more so than a monitoring specialist to take a reflective pause and look back at what has been. That’s why some of these big numbers persist in our industry — unfortunately it’s still where the majority of PR teams are receiving their data from.”

— Steph Bridgman

The Rise of In-House Measurement

There is a significant evolution underway. AMEC is seeing much more involvement from in-house teams and PR agencies, not just dedicated measurement firms.

“The differentiator for agencies is going to be saying that we’re not a cost centre, we’re a value-add centre. The incentive for agencies to invest a relatively small proportion of their overall cost in in-house measurement skills should yield quite significant dividends in terms of the ability to show value.”

— Paul Hender

For a 50-person agency, it makes sense that one or two people have some kind of data background or at least data competence. The model can be full-time hires or fractional consultants. What matters is that the capability exists.

“I’m a big believer in divide and conquer — what economists call comparative advantage. It’s better to split the skills out and do it as a team rather than one person trying to do everything. Think about how ad agencies were structured: half were creatives and half were analysts. In a fragmented media landscape where saying the wrong thing to the wrong audience can damage your reputation, having strategy, critical thinking, and analysis alongside the creative side is going to be a pretty valuable thing.”

— Paul Hender

Key Takeaway

Measurement is not just for measurement agencies. Every PR team — whether agency or in-house — needs someone who can bridge the gap between data and storytelling.

Chapter 7: The Future of PR Measurement

The landscape of PR measurement is shifting in several important directions. Here is what our experts see on the horizon.

AI: Useful, But Not a Silver Bullet

AI is everywhere in the conversation right now — and yes, it has real potential to reduce costs and scale analysis. But the reality is more nuanced than the hype suggests.

“I’m a big believer in the Gartner hype curve. Gen AI is actually plunging into the trough of disillusionment. A lot of people will have been doing trials on AI but will be either a little bit underwhelmed or not able to scale their experiments. There’s a McKinsey report showing that 90% of organisations are experimenting with AI, but more than two-thirds have not been able to actually implement it at scale.

I think there’ll be a backlash against the AI hype trend, and there’ll be a realisation about where humans add value — particularly in critical thinking around how comms works.”

— Paul Hender

Part of the challenge isn’t just the technology — it’s the data AI is being asked to work with.

Most PR coverage today is still unstructured. It lives in PDFs, links, screenshots, and reports. It hasn’t been consistently tagged, categorised, or organised in a way that machines can reliably interpret.

Which means when AI is applied, it’s often being asked to make sense of messy, inconsistent inputs. The result?

- Inconsistent outputs
- Shallow or generic insights
- And analysis that still requires significant human checking

In many cases, what’s being presented as “AI-powered analysis” is still heavily reliant on Boolean keyword matching layered with light automation. And that creates a fundamental limitation.

PR doesn’t work in exact phrases. Messages are rarely delivered verbatim.

“Messages are never conveyed verbatim. One client might have a message that they’re a socially responsible company, but the journalist is never going to say ‘X Company is a socially responsible company.’ So you have to look for inference of the message. That keyword approach — it’s going to miss loads, and you need to double-check it anyway.”

— Steph Bridgman

Without structured coverage data, AI struggles to:

- Reliably identify which messages are landing
- Compare performance across campaigns, markets, or tactics
- Or surface patterns that can confidently inform strategy

In other words, AI can accelerate analysis — but it can’t fix poor inputs.

The Real Opportunity

The real opportunity isn’t just applying AI to PR. It’s **structuring PR data in a way that makes AI useful**. That means:

- Consistent classification of coverage
- Clear tagging of messages, tactics, and outcomes
- And a shared framework for how data is organised

Because once that structure exists, AI becomes far more powerful — not as a replacement for human judgement, but as a way to scale it.

Until then, human interpretation remains essential — especially when it comes to nuance, context, and strategic thinking.

The Return of Market Mix Modelling

There is a move away from last-click attribution due to increasing privacy concerns and cookie restrictions. Even Google and Meta — the two organisations most invested in attribution marketing — have invested in open-source market mix modelling tools. This approach uses statistics to model how all marketing disciplines collectively affect business outcomes, and it works very well for communications measurement.

“Nothing is exact out there. Even your advertising measurement won’t be exact. But if you can just have some kind of consistency and look for correlations or some kind of journey to build up a picture, that’s the most important thing.”

— Paul Hender

A Final Question...

“If your coverage data were structured consistently today, what strategic decision would become easier tomorrow?”

The shift from retrospective reporting to strategic measurement is not about buying more tools or generating more data. It is about asking better questions, structuring your data with intent, and having the confidence to present smaller, credible numbers that drive real decisions.

Start with your objectives. Embrace the smaller number. Structure your data consistently. Tell the story in 30 seconds. And remember:

“Here’s what we’re learning — and here’s what we’re changing.”

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About the Author

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About CoverageBook

CoverageBook creates beautifully designed PR reports with credible metrics you can be proud of. From simply pasting links the platform helps PR professionals move from visibility to insightful reports in minutes. Visit **coveragebook.com** for your free trial.